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Sister of Mercy

By Clyde Hendrickson

[*A teenage girl. She sits at a table with a few items on it, in a blank room*.]

This is the bronze star the Army gave my brother for bravery. It was awarded to him posthumously, for actions above and beyond the call of duty. "Posthumously," in case you didn't know, means "after his death." I'm not sure if the Army considers dying above and beyond the call of duty. [*joking*] Seems more like a dereliction of duty to me.

Some people seem to think that I should be angry that the army gave my dead brother a medal for bravery. Like, it doesn't make up for his death. Not even close. But I think you *should* get a medal for bravery. Being brave is hard, and not many of us are up to the task. What my brother did, maybe it was heroic, maybe it was stupid, but it was definitely brave. And it inspired me. I've never been that brave. Not to sound like a douche, but, maybe if some of us were as brave as he was, he wouldn't have needed to go over there in the first place.

Bravery is what got me here, telling you the story. Well, the telling ain't brave. It's stupid. But what I did, was brave. Brave the way my brother was. Or maybe brave like the terrorist who shot my brother was.

I wasn't thinking about bravery at my brother's funeral. I was thinking about the story my parents loved to tell about him, when he was three. This was before I was born. He was having his first piece of fried chicken ever, that my dad had cut up for him. He ate it, chewed it up slowly, and then spit it out. "Tastes like mommy's shoes!" He said. And both my parents laughed, it was a silly thing to say. But my mom stopped laughing. She was thinking, that morning, she hadn't been able to find her favorite sandals. It was the second pair that had gone missing recently and she was pretty mad. She said, "Honey, do you eat mommy's shoes?" And my brother just giggled like crazy. My dad just looked confused. Then they went to my brother's room, and looked under his pile of stuffed animals. And there were the shoes, chewed on like my brother was a Labrador puppy or something! They tried to get mad at him but they just laughed and laughed. My brother still won't eat fried chicken, and my mom still keeps her shoes on the top shelf of her closet, though there's no proof my brother's habit continued.

That was basically the only good story I ever heard about him as a baby. I wonder if my parents will talk to me more about him now. Or will we never speak of him again? So far, I can't tell.

It was my dad who started crying first, at the funeral. None of us are criers. We're all real believers in Christ, you know, and we have this natural, Jesus-kind-of happiness that comes over us as soon as one of us gets sad. If something bad happens, we know God had a reason. When my brother died, we knew he was with the lord. On the way to the funeral, we sang a song my brother loved, an oldie, "Who wrote the book of Love," that song always made him cheer right up. My dad was singing the loudest. So it took a lot to get my dad to start crying.

It took a band of protesters showing up at my brother's funeral to make my dad cry. To be specific. It was when one of them shouted into a megaphone, "Your son died because you love fags!" And then the priest was praying and we got "America is paying for its sins." By the time they started singing "Lords gonna burn these fags in hell" I was crying too, but out of rage. I violently sneezed, I was physically ill.

Apparently, Pastor Melville and his extended family do this at funerals of soldiers across the country. They think the whole country's being punished for its sins. Even the families that are good Christians, like mine, and even for all the good things we do. Pastor Melville thinks we're evil, and weak. He doesn't know about our bravery.

I actually started shouting at them. I was shouting for them to go away, I interrupted the pastor's prayer. I was so mad. My dad grabbed me but I broke free, I stormed towards the Melvilles, I was screaming at them. And they were laughing at me. One of them was singing, they were all smiling. "Look at the little demon get mad. Back to hell, Demon, with your faggot-loving brother!" That's what Pastor Melville said to me. My brother's Army friends picked me up and carried me away.

You might be wondering why I'm telling you all this from a jail cell. Well, that's the point of this story. That's where it's headed.

The rage that got in me when I saw those protestors didn't leave. Night after night it haunted me. I did not mourn for my brother, I did not help my parents, I did not go back to school. I was consumed by rage. I had to do something.

In high school, we read Dante's Inferno. It's pretty intense, it led to a couple nightmares of being frozen in ice for all eternity. I remember always this one part, where Dante meets someone in hell he knows is still alive. And he tells Dante that sometimes, people are so bad, devils come and take them to hell, and replace them on earth with a monster, before they die. After I first thought of killing those people, Pastor Melville, and his family, I couldn't stop. It

tortured me, that memory, and the memory of my dad crying, and the idea that maybe they were right, maybe my brother was in hell. And I could only think of revenge and death. I think I might have gone to hell at that very moment when I decided to kill one of them. Ever since, I've just been half-demon. I'm condemned, definitely. If you went to hell now, I would already be there.

It was easy to track down Pastor Melville and his family online. They preach out of their compound in Tennessee. They live there. And god bless this country, it was so easy to buy a gun. The gun show dealer was so proud of me for being a woman standing up for my rights.

I got to the Melville compound in the early evening. I knew they were leaving for a protest. They put it in on their blog. I saw them leave, in two vans, windows open. They were singing hymns. Piled in the back of the last vans were their signs. "United States of Faggots" I read. They were gone. The sun set. I went in the house, to see what I could do. I had my gun, and a can of gasoline. I figured I'd just burn it to the ground. The gun was for my protection.

I was on the second floor when I heard something. A cough. One of them was still home. The adrenaline rush was indescribable. I was so excited. I knew I was going to kill whoever I found, man, woman or child. It was a teenage boy, actually. About my age. I came in the room. I wish I could say I found him praying, but he was just sitting there, looking out the window, blowing his nose. Like a real person.

If you're wondering, he did look at me before I shot him in his goddamn head. Sorry for swearing.

Sitting there in the house, next to the dead body, I thought of my brother. One time after school he took me to 7-11 to get a Slurpee. We were talking about the usually boring stuff. When we were standing outside, letting the sun battle the brain freeze from the drinks, I thought of something that had happened that day at school. "Hey, at school today, we found out one kid was a gay faggot because he touched another kid's butt on purpose!" My brother turned to me. He looked really angry, almost like he wanted to shake me. He said, "Mercy, I don't like those folks any more than you do, but I don't hate 'em. Don't call them names. Don't ever do that. That's just hate." I'm not sure I said the word "faggot" out loud again until I told you all about the protestors, what they said. And next to that dead body, thinking about my brother's love, I cried. I cried, and cried, with real sadness this time. Then, with the sadness gone, the rage gone, I was empty. I pointed the gun at myself, but my bravery was gone.

After I realized I would find no peace, I called the police myself. I didn't lie to them. I had no trouble telling them my story, briefly. It was my parents I couldn't talk to. I couldn't get a word out, I just cried. And they didn't smile, either. I don't think they were singing songs on the way

to the prison. I don't think they know what God was thinking this time. I don't want to know what He had in mind.

[*She picks up the bronze star again*.] They're not going to give me a medal. So this one is for me and my brother. We're both just as stupid, we're both heroic, we're both brave. I took this before I left, and I kept it. The prison officers, they had sympathy for me, they let me keep it. I'm going to keep it until the end. I'm not much of a fighter, but those girls in prison better watch out if they try and touch this medal. Although, I guess as a teenage killer, I already have a pretty tough reputation. I got this medal for it.

I told the police one lie, though. And I lied to you, too. I told them that I found the boy, and as soon as I saw him, I shot him. But that wasn't true. He wanted to chat. He was happy to talk to me, even after he saw the gun, even after he knew exactly why I was there.

"Do you know who I am?" I asked him.

He shook his head.

"You were at my brother's funeral the other day."

"Praise Jesus," he cried out in loud whisper. "Have you come to bring me to the Lord?"

"I think I have,"

"You can do nothing to my faith, demon, whatever you do to my body." He had fallen to his knees. He put out his arms, to receive a blessing.

"I'm not a demon, I'm only a sinner," I needed him to know the difference. Because sinners are supposed to deserve mercy, and compassion. That's what I'd been taught.

"Hate the sin," I said, "Love the sinner."

"Think about the order," he replied. "You must hate first, and then love."
"You'll never love," I said. "You wouldn't know how!"

"I'm sorry if I can't love faggots and queers and whores and heathens like you can. I can only love God."

"God is in all those people." I'm sorry, I'm shaking now as much as I was then.

"Satan is in them!" He hissed back.

"He's in you too!"

“I know,” he said, “and I thank you. You’re about to take him out, for good.” He smiled that sweet, sure smile. God I wish I hadn’t felt that he could be right. Maybe we are all sinners.

“If your brother had repented, maybe that sand devil that shot him might have taken Satan out too.”

“How do you know if he repented?”

“He’s a sinner, like you.”

I turned away, “Judge not, lest ye be judged.”

He was laughing. Laughing. “What’s so funny?”

“God is judging. He judged your brother in blood. I know he’s a sinner.”

I turned back to him.

“Then why are you about to die?”

He smiled.

“Did you know my brother’s name?”

He looked at me with real eyes for the first time. He was surprised.

“I did not,” he said.

“You attacked at random,” I said. “Like a dog.”

“Vengeance finds a way.” He wasn’t sure. He wondered what else he didn’t know.

“My brother’s name was Alex.” I realize I haven’t told you all that either. Alex was my brother. He died and got a medal for his bravery.

(She is looking at the killer again.)

“He died because he was brave. Maybe that’s why you are dying too.”

He smiled again. “I am dying for the Lord.”

“What’s your name?” I asked.

“Tom Melville.”

“I’m going to kill you, Tom.”

I cocked the gun. He looked away. “Satan, get behind me!”

And then I thought about my brother. When he would walk me to the playground and push me on the swings, higher than anyone else would, as I laughed and cried with joy. He was pushing me now. I felt the wind around me, the tears in my eyes, I put the gun in this kid’s face and I said,

“Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on us, we are nothing but poor sinners.”